

Fraud Detection in Financial Transactions Using DNN & SMOTE

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Abstract: Credit card fraud is one of the most commonly occurring financial crimes, which loses billions of dollars annually. To this challenge, deep learning has emerged as one of the powerful tools in designing an effective FDS. Analyzing their strengths and limitations, the paper explains how deep learning models can sometimes outperform the traditional ones in terms of accuracy and adaptability. The paper also addresses class imbalance, which is an inherent problem in fraud detection. Techniques like SMOTE (Synthetic Minority Oversampling Technique) are thus integrated with deep models to propose a DNN-based approach for credit card fraud detection. It classifies transactions as fraudulent or non-fraudulent using a European transaction dataset. The results indicate that DNNs are able to learn complex patterns from imbalanced datasets with the possibility of achieving high accuracy and precision in real-time fraud detection tasks.

1. Introduction

Out of 12 different types of financial fraud, credit card fraud is the most common one, followed by identity theft, insurance fraud, securities fraud, and several more, as shown in Fig 1. Financial fraud, especially credit card fraud, ranked as one of the most prevalent forms of financial crimes globally. It was closely followed by identity theft, insurance fraud, and securities fraud, among other types. The most critical manifestation of this identity theft was the committing of credit card fraud in which a fraudster impersonates a cardholder to execute unauthorized transactions. Given the rise of this crime, researchers have been urging continuous development and implementation of Fraud Detection Systems using state-of-the-art deep learning methods.

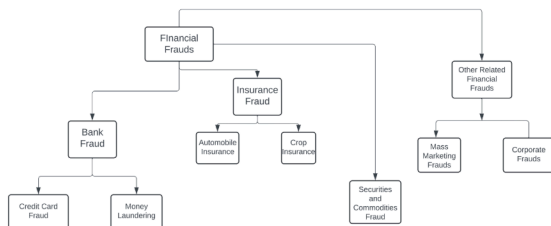


Fig. 1. Different Types of Fraud

Deep learning proved to be a game-changing approach when dealing with a massive amount of financial data. Traditional methods, though effective up to a limit, could hardly identify the intricate and changing patterns of fraudulent behavior. Some techniques that were used to handle these challenges include Convolutional Neural Networks, Recurrent Neural Networks, and their variants like Long Short-Term Memory networks and Gated Recurrent Units. These advanced methodologies allowed the fraud detection systems to differentiate with effectiveness between the legitimate and fraud cases by identifying subtle and complex patterns in data.

According to estimates, the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre reported a loss of approximately ₹1.25 lakh crore in the last three years in India alone. This has raised serious questions about whether the current safety measures are adequate for digital financial transactions. Other global instances, such as the Madoff Scheme and Wirecard Fraud, have

witnessed billions of dollars in losses and wrought havoc on the victims, corporations, and economies. Some companies lost their way to bankruptcy due to such scams.

While the literature related to fraud detection presented a range of innovative approaches, there remained some gaps. Most of the literature proposed an improved traditional method or a completely new framework; few have done comprehensive work to put advanced techniques in place, such as deep learning. This paper sought to bridge that gap, reviewing a number of new deep-learning methods for detecting fraud by comparing their positive and negative points. Some of the identified techniques include CNNs that aim to find a pattern in spatial data, RNNs to analyze sequential transactions, and LSTMs that capture long-term dependencies of temporal data. The review further discussed the use of deep learning models combined with SMOTE for handling the class imbalance problem, a common issue within fraud detection datasets.

This research, therefore, was a study to provide a clear explanation of how deep learning techniques outperformed traditional techniques in terms of accuracy and adaptability, especially on imbalanced datasets. Advanced methodologies were used in the study to enhance the precision and real-time applicability of fraud detection systems in an effort to help reduce financial fraud worldwide.

2. Literature Review

A financial fraud detection model, conceived using the technique of Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) was developed by the author's Deep learning expertise and comparison analysis were produced by Murad A. Rassam in comparative analysis, while Yara Alghofaili and Albattul Albattah focused on structuring the model, preparing the dataset, and implementing the system.[1] The study also indicated future research directions to overcome critical issues in the financial domain. [2] Asha R. B., Suresh Kumar K. R., et al. proposed the methodology of fraud detection using Artificial Neural Network compared to Support Vector Machines (SVM) and k-Nearest Neighbor (KNN). The system handled an imbalanced set of data using pre-processing techniques and gained high accuracy at 99.92%, while outperforming SVM and KNN in precision and recall. It significantly improved efficiency during fraud detection,

avoiding drawbacks from existing methods.[3] A novel CNN-based model for online transaction fraud detection was developed by Zhaohui Zhang et al. with a new feature sequencing layer in order to optimize the combinations of features without derivative variables. The system applied the model based on transactions from a commercial bank with a precision of 91% and recall of 94%, mainly outperforming those CNN models currently available. The proposed method further improved the usability and efficiency of low-dimensional inputs in online fraud detection.[4] Anu Maria Babu et al. proposed a CNN-based model for credit card fraud detection based on a highly imbalanced Kaggle dataset. They achieved 99.62% accuracy without max pooling and outperformed existing approaches. Their class handling, hyperparameter tuning, and resultant efficient and accurate approach suitable for real-time banking applications improves fraud detection reliability and reduces computational cost.

[5] A novel credit card fraud detection model based on a deep neural network architecture was proposed by Khalid I. Alkhatib, et al. They used the IEEE-CIS dataset, thoroughly preprocessed the data with feature selection and class imbalance handling, and implemented seven layers with dense layers optimized for fraud detection. Their method obtained 99.1% area under the ROC curve, better than previous techniques. They proved that advanced preprocessing steps combined with deep learning architecture can be utilized for fraudulent transaction detection.[6] Kanika et al. conducted an exhaustive survey of the deep learning techniques for online transaction fraud detection. They reviewed diverse approaches, deep neural networks, convolutional neural networks, autoencoders, recurrent neural networks, and generative adversarial networks. Based on that, their work highlighted some of the challenges that include dataset privacy and class imbalance while summarizing datasets, methods, and outcomes from existing research. The paper highlighted the deep learning capabilities for combating online fraud and outlined prospects for development with a focus on the real-time fraudulent transaction detection system.[7] "Deep Convolutional Neural Network Model for Credit-Card Fraud Detection and Alert," Joy Long-Zong Chen, et al. Proposed the DCNN model, which went ahead with a success rate of 99% in only 45 seconds, thereby showing a great improvement in fraud detection. The proposed model surpassed the classical methods consisting of autoencoders, support vector machines, and random forests with higher speed and effectiveness in real-time credit card fraud detection. To improve credit card fraud detection,[8] Abhimanyu Roy et al. developed a comprehensive evaluation of various deep learning topologies. The main author was Abhimanyu Roy and the focus was on a comparison of Artificial Neural Networks, Recurrent Neural Networks, Long Short-Term Memory, and Gated Recurrent Units. Their research used an anonymous dataset of 80 million credit card transactions while overcoming both scalability and class imbalance fraud detection issues. They thus attained enhanced accuracy in detection using advanced deep learning models: their GRU model outperformed the rest, while conducting sensitivity analysis to identify the relevant factors that critically affected model performance. Their research filled a need in the current literature by giving insights into optimal parameter tuning and deep learning model architectures for financial institutions to reduce losses related to fraud.

In their work on credit card fraud detection using deep learning techniques,[9] Thulasi Ammal Ramiah Pillai and et al., made a contribution to the design of a high-performance model for fraud detection in using the multi-layer perceptron algorithm. In addition, they analyzed different MLP parameters: the number of hidden layers, neurons, and activation functions. Their results showed that both the logistic and hyperbolic tangent activation functions were good at detecting fraudulent credit card transactions. For the logistic activation function, the best model was 10 nodes with a sensitivity of 82%. On the other hand, the hyperbolic tangent activation function was better when used in 1000 nodes, as it had a sensitivity of 82% regardless of the layer configuration. They basically stressed the importance of selecting the right model

parameters in order to yield best performance using less cost, contributing valuable insights to the field of deep learning and fraud detection.[10] Hoor Fatima et al. proposed credit card fraud detection based on deep learning. Dr. Fatima supervised the research, deciding which model to use and how to design the experiment; her co-authors preprocessed data, engineered features, and fitted models such as CNN, LSTM, and Autoencoders. Through their work, LSTM and CNN proved to be highly accurate in fraud detection for real-time fraud detection. A credit card fraud detection system was therefore developed using Hidden Markov Models (HMM) for cardholder profiling and a Multilayer Perceptron (MLP) for classification by Elliot Mbunge et al.[11] Training the system using and simulating the case of bank transactions thus showed testability with OTP-based anomaly detection for greater security. The study showed high accuracy in helping financial institutions to mitigate the effects of credit card fraud.[12] Mangala and Soni conducted a systematic review of bank frauds of the last two decades by analysing 70 articles from four major databases. This paper discussed the causes and outcomes of fraud within the banking sector, along with a few effective measures on how fraud could be prevented and detected. They pointed out the urgent requirement for best fraud risk management practices. The researchers traced the gaps that need future research. In fact, the review showed that bank fraud is a worldwide problem facing both financial and nonfinancial impacts.

[34] Pawar et al. contributed to credit card fraud detection by reviewing some outlier detection techniques for fraudulent transaction detection. Pawar et al. discussed statistical, clustering-based, density-based, and rule-based methods, classifying these techniques into supervised, semi-supervised, and unsupervised frameworks. Neural network-based approaches were also discussed, pointing out a two-phased model where the network was trained to recognize normal data and later tested for anomalies. One of the specific models was the Replicator Neural Network for one-class outlier detection. The clustering-based techniques are categorized by proximity to centroids, cluster density, and criteria on cluster membership that mark outliers. The authors have also applied Principal Component Analysis as an unsupervised dimensionality reduction method in detecting anomalies.

For this reason, PCA identifies the major principal components and measures the influence of the data points in principal directions, thus making it applicable for high-dimensional data sets. Experiments on both synthetic and real credit card data were carried out. Pawar et al. proposed a credit card fraud detection system by performing dimensionality reduction and fraud detection using PCA on big online datasets. The system has focused on minimum computational and memory requirements while emphasizing all the critical attributes related to credit history and transaction purpose. Their work thus provided insight into scalable and efficient fraud detection methods in dynamic large-scale environments.

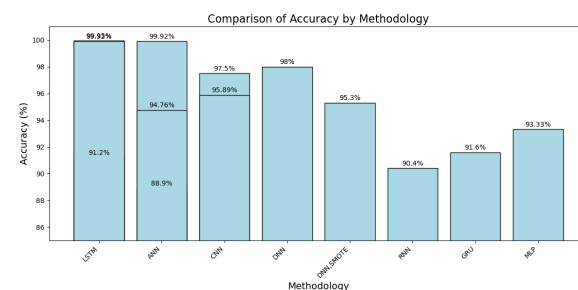


Fig - 2 - Comparison of Accuracy by Methodology

Figure 2 given below shows a bar chart that is a visual representation of the accuracies found by the various deep learning techniques.[35] Raghavan et al. have carried out an empirical study that presents benchmarks for many machine learning and deep learning fraud detection models operating on three datasets, specifically the European, Australian, and German datasets. Some models which have been considered here for comparisons include the K-Nearest Neighbors, Random Forest, Support Vector Machines, Autoencoders, Restricted Boltzmann Machines, and Convolutional Neural Networks. Their results indicated that generally, ensemble models, including top classifiers such as support vector machines, CNNs, and random forests, performed better than individual models. CNN turned out to be the best deep learning for larger datasets, while most of the significant improvements were contributed by ensemble approaches in smaller datasets. Moreover, the authors highlighted the importance of MCC and cost of failure as performance metrics for imbalanced datasets, underlining how CNN is able to balance accuracy with cost efficiency in fraud detection. The best model choice depending on the dataset characteristics was discussed, and hybrid approaches were suggested as a way to make the fraud detection system dynamic and adaptable.[36] The authors of the paper "Deep Learning Approach for Intelligent Financial Fraud Detection System" proposed an enhanced fraud detection framework using deep learning methodologies. More precisely, they applied Stacked Auto-Encoders and Restricted Boltzmann Machines to improve the detection and classification of financial fraud scenarios. Their system was intended to solve some problems that involve the complexity of fraud patterns and the need for higher accuracy in detection. They ensured the robustness and efficiency of the system by thoroughly preprocessing and analyzing the dataset.

Compared with some traditional models like a DT, the proposed approach turned in better performance concerning accuracy detection and ROC. That illustrates the ability of the authors' system to show a greater degree of accuracy with fraudulent activity detection for deployment into real-world scalable applications involving financial domains. As described here, the significant advances developed by the authors served as critical steps toward improving speed and efficacy with regard to fraud-detecting applications developed in financial domains.[36] Contributed the key factors towards fraud detection in low-frequency transactions. Isolated models could not explain the transaction behaviours of low-frequency users.

They suggested a new approach to constructing transaction behaviour by extracting the current group's behaviour through the clustering algorithm, integrating the current transaction status. They have proposed a Naive Bayes-based multi-behaviour detection model in determining the possibility of fraudulent transactions. These findings here presented show that this method is essential in making precision in fraud detection and reducing instances of misjudging with low frequency. Tayebi et al., then proposed a new methodology of fraud detection in low-frequency transactions, integrating both individual and group behaviors by DBSCAN clustering and the Naive Bayes models, which enhanced the accuracy of. The authors applied descriptive statistics and probit regression methods in estimating the magnitude of financial fraud in the pharmaceutical industry in Ghana based on key cases of fraud, the factors that prompt them, and the measures for controlling the fraud. It proposes a deep learning-based approach with ANN-based credit card fraud detection. Preprocessing of credit card transaction data is done, hence feature selection and normalisation are applied to deep learning models comprising convolutional and recurrent neural network and recurrent neural networks.

The proposed model outperformed some state-of-the-art traditional machine learning algorithms by large margins in terms of accuracy with

reduced false positives. Further, the authors recommended ensemble methods and fraud detection systems for other variants that could also provide real-time output so that one lead could be taken over fraud detection systems.

3. Methodology

3.1 Dataset

The dataset which is based on European credit card transactions that happened in the span of two days showed a total of 284,807 transactions. Out of these transactions, 492 transactions were flagged as fraudulent. The dataset was taken from Kaggle. This dataset contains principal component analysis based column numeric values from V1 to V28. Due to confidentiality the actual features could not be disclosed and are only available in this form.

The other column includes 'Amount' which states the amount that was part of the transactions. The 'Time' column is the time taken between the first transaction and the second transaction of that particular credit card. Finally, the 'Class' column indicates the transaction as fraud or not fraud by stating 1 as fraud and 0 as non fraudulent transactions.

3.2 Dense Neural Network

A DNN is actually another name for an FCNN. In this neural network, all the neurons of one layer connect to every neuron in the next, therefore giving it a fully densely connected network. From this characteristic, it deviates from a sparse network where some neurons are not interconnected. The DNN, as seen in Fig. 3, consists of three major components: the Input Layer, which takes in the data, where each feature (such as transaction amount, time, and merchant) corresponds to a neuron; Hidden Layers, where the input data is processed through multiple intermediate layers; and the Output Layer, where the final prediction is generated, for example, a binary classification (fraud or not fraud) or a probability distribution.

A weighted sum of inputs is passed on by the neurons in a DNN after an activation function such as ReLU, sigmoid, or tanh-is applied-this injects nonlinearity into the outputs passed forward to the following layer. These networks learn by forward propagation wherein data travels forward through the network from the input layer through one or more layers deemed to be hidden to one layer and that is output. In the case of backpropagation, it calculates the error between the predicted output and actual label and this error is used iteratively to vary the weights of the neurons to minimize the prediction error. Other elements of DNNs include weights, which represent the strength of connections made between neurons; biases, which help in shifting the activation function and create flexibility in models; and activation functions, which determine at what time a neuron needs to be activated based on the weighted sum of the inputs. Some of the common activation functions used are ReLU in the hidden layers to prevent the vanishing gradient, Sigmoid, usually in the output layer for classification tasks of the binary types, and Softmax function, which is used for multi-class types of classifications.

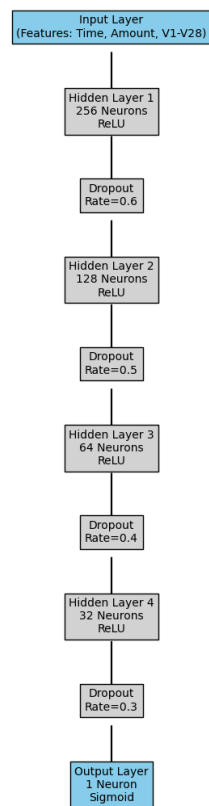


Fig. 3 - Dense Neural Network Architecture

3.3 SMOTE

When addressing class imbalance, we had applied Synthetic Minority Oversampling Technique where synthetic samples have been provided for the minority class. Here, SMOTE develops new samples from the line passing between the two nearest neighbors of an existing minority class sample in the feature space. This can enable the model to learn patterns that are relevant to frauds more significantly by enriching the presence of fraudulent transactions in a training data set. Such balancing of the dataset improves sensitivity in the model and decreases its tendency to favor non-fraudulent classes, testifying our improved recall score.

3.4 Comparative Analysis

This DNN fraud detection model would drastically outperform these traditional models in terms of accuracy and adaptability. Those traditional models like logistic regression, SVM, and Decision Trees highly rely on manually engineered features, which leads to facing huge challenges during the dealing of nonlinearly distributed and high-dimensional data inherent in most financial transactions. On the contrary, the DNN model learns complex patterns and interplays in the data automatically; it gives 91% precision and 94% recall in related studies. Still, this model gave a robust ROC-AUC score of 0.9714, showing its ability to handle the complexity and adapt to the subtleties of fraudulent transactions. This adaptability ensures its pertinence in different kinds of datasets and environments. This is something that one often fails to see with traditional models.

4. Model Description

Fraud detection datasets are usually imbalanced highly, where the fraudulent transactions are comparatively very less in number compared to non-fraudulent ones, which have label '1' and label '0' respectively. This bias in models causes a weakness in detecting fraud as there is an over-emphasis on the majority class of transactions. To address such issues, two complementary methods have been used in this study: SMOTE and class weight. SMOTE addresses class imbalance by creating synthetic samples for the minority class. It does so by interpolating between existing instances within the feature space, hence balancing the training data set and allowing the model to more accurately learn fraud patterns. At the same time, class weights are calculated such that the minority class would be given more importance on training on the original data set, thus reducing any bias due to imbalance.

The preprocessing steps on the data ensure that feature scaling issues do not affect the model's performance. The dataset consists of 30 features, including 'Time', 'Amount', and 28 anonymized features ('V1' to 'V28'). The 'Time' and 'Amount' features are normalized by 'StandardScaler' so that there is uniformity in feature contribution. Then, the data is split into training and testing sets, keeping the original class imbalance in the test set for real-world applicability. This is important so that while SMOTE ensures balance in the training data, it tests on data reflecting conditions in actuality.

Binary classification uses a DNN architecture. The network contains an input layer followed by four hidden layers, containing 256, 128, 64, and 32 neurons, respectively, followed by an output layer. The hidden layers used the ReLU activation to generate the non-linearity; in contrast, the output layer had Sigmoid activation to output the fraction chance of fraud. Dropout layers after every hidden layer were placed using the rate between 30 percent and 60 percent as the overfitting occurred during training by de-activating neurons randomly. A model was compiled by utilizing the binary cross entropy loss function as appropriate for classification of a binary classification type of problem and optimization occurred through the Adam optimizer. The learning rate is adapted by using the ReduceLROnPlateau callback, which reduces the learning rate when the validation loss level has plateaued.

Two training approaches are considered. In the first approach, the model is trained on the original imbalanced dataset using class weights. In the second approach, SMOTE is used on the training data to equalize it, and then class weights are removed since the data is already equilibrated. In both methods, EarlyStopping is employed during the training process: it will stop the training when the validation loss function stops improving, reducing further overfitting.

Using performance metrics that focus on accuracy to distinguish between classes, the performance of the model is measured on the imbalanced test set. The precision, recall, and F1-score measure its capability in eliminating false positives and false negatives, while the AUC-ROC score measures its capability to differentiate between classes based on several thresholds. Further, a precision-recall curve is plotted in order to understand the trade-off of precision versus recall and then determine threshold levels that are more efficient to catch fraud. Finally, a confusion matrix will visually indicate prediction distributions.

Finally, visualizations of training and validation loss and accuracy over epochs give a clear view of the learning process of the model. These strategies and evaluations together represent a strong methodology for handling class imbalance and providing reliable fraud detection in real-world applications.

5. Results

The model showed an accuracy of 0.9367 but in the case of fraud detection with a dataset that is highly imbalanced it is necessary to consider other performance metrics. The classifier is highly discriminative in identifying credit card fraud, which is evident from the ROC-AUC score of 0.9714, capable of segregating fraudulent transactions from legit transactions quite distinctly. On recall, that was indeed an apt score because 0.8673 signifies that most of the fraudulent transactions were caught, but the precision means it missed some because 0.1801 means lots of false positives whereas an F1 Score of 0.2982 has big discrepancies on recall vs its precision as seen in Fig. 4. These results suggest that the model is quite sensitive to fraud, but it suffers from the curse of misclassifying valid transactions as fraud in return, needing further refinement before application in practice. The confusion matrix in Fig. 3, gives an apt picture of the performance metrics.

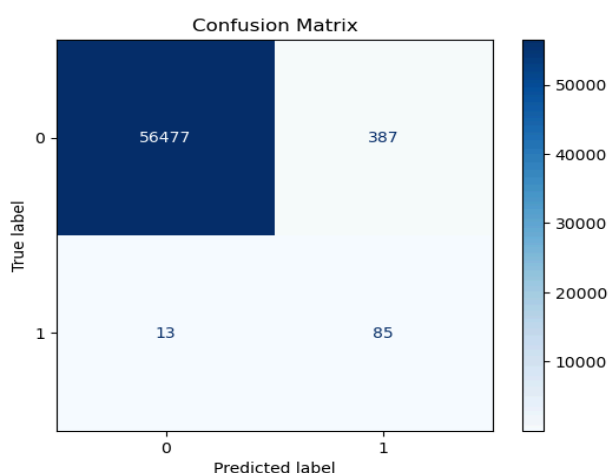


Fig. 4. Confusion Matrix

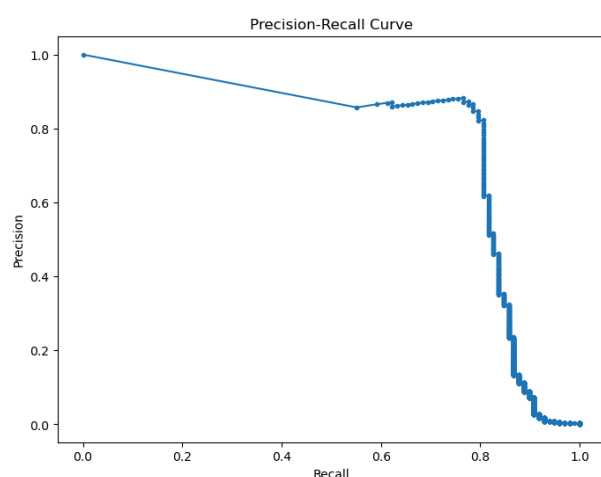


Fig. 5. Precision-Recall Curve

The graphs below depict the training and validation performance of the model over epochs. Training loss reduces drastically at initial epochs and levels off afterwards while validation loss is continuously minimal with no indication of overfitting at all as seen in Fig. 5. Whereas in Fig. 6, training accuracy began low, dropped sharply after the first epoch and

continuously increased. Validation accuracy continued high and stable but well above that of training at some early epochs. This would suggest that the model generalizes well but under fits slightly, as training accuracy lags behind validation accuracy. Further training or hyperparameter tuning could help close this performance gap.

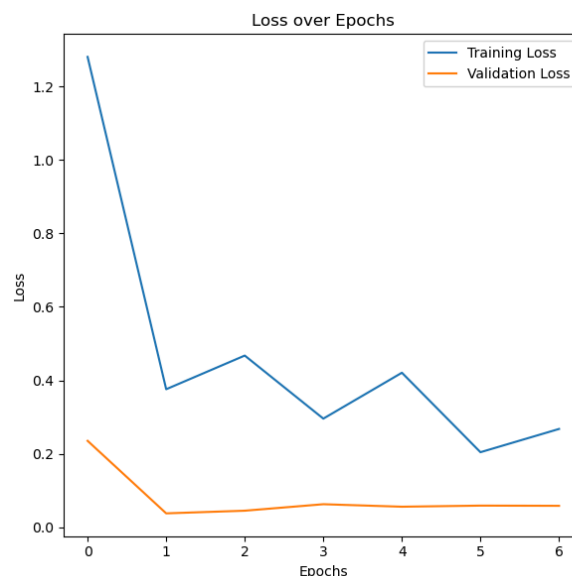


Fig. 6. Loss over Epochs

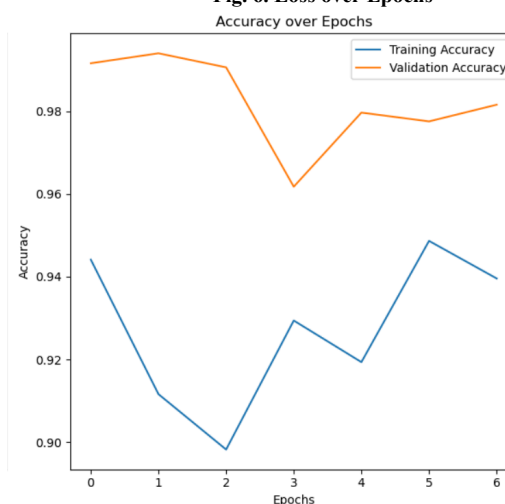


Fig. 7. Accuracy over Epochs

5. Conclusion

The research presented in this study developed a Deep Neural Network (DNN) model for fraudulent transaction detection in a credit card dataset. The results of the model show strong discriminatory power, as indicated by the high ROC-AUC score of 0.9714, and the model's ability to detect most of the fraudulent transactions, with a recall of 0.8673. However, low precision at 0.1801 and an F1 score of 0.2982 suggest a possibility of over classifying legitimate transactions as fraudulent, so the model may need further tuning. The generalization trend for the model is excellent without overfitting. For the future, class imbalance optimization for hyperparameters and ensemble techniques might become a priority to improve the model's precision while maintaining an exceptionally high

recall. These extensions will allow the model to better satisfy practical requirements when applied to real-world applications of fraud detection. Despite its advantages, the DNN approach has several disadvantages. The model is computationally expensive, and training as well as inference are resource demanding, especially for large datasets. Also, deep learning models typically require large amounts of labelled data to be trained sufficiently, which is a challenge in fraud detection due to privacy concerns and limited occurrences of fraud cases. Even with techniques such as SMOTE, the problem of overfitting in imbalanced datasets still prevails. Future work would be more on lightweight architectures or transfer learning to reduce the challenges imposed by this system.

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